to ditch it at a delicate moment in state and national politics.

In response, Congress MP Manickam Tagore says the party always deserved a more meaningful role in governance and that "power-sharing is essential". A share in power is also loaded with significance for the VCK. "Cadres overwhelmingly supported the idea of joining the cabinet. It's not about power, but about who gets access to power," says political observer Mudhalvan.

The rebel AIADMK's absence is telling. Sources suggest the TVK leadership was wary of the risks involved in onboarding 'defectors' and insisted that such MLAs resign and recontest under the TVK symbol, and the MLAs were apparently unwilling. Rebel leaders C. Ve Shanmugam and S.P. Velumani now find themselves in an uncomfortable position, allowing AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami the last laugh—at least for now!

Takeaways

- **Dalit-based VCK gets a ministry for first time ever, so does IUML—in TN**
- **Congress, too, gets office after decades, igniting war of words with jilted DMK**
- **TVK cadre embark on controversial 'camera raids' in state govt offices**

Tamil Nadu has many optimists who look forward to a generational shift in governance, but some flag the TVK's inexperience. That concern was underlined by some TVK cadre across the state who went on what are being called "camera inspections"—surprise visits to state facilities, with the proceedings being recorded. "It's the first time they are in power and it shows," says a senior journalist. "But if Vijay is serious about delivering clean governance, he should rein them in." ■



▶ UTTAR PRADESH

A Trail Opens For Those Who Witness the Path in Silence

Going beyond Ayodhya-Kashi-Mathura, UP opens up the Nath sect's spiritual circuit to the mindful

By **Avaneesh Mishra**

ITS OLDER CIRCUIT WAS KNOWN across India for centuries: Kashi, Mathura, then Prayagraj (Allahabad) for the Kumbh. Recent years have added to that Ayodhya, reinvented as a 21st-century pilgrimage hotspot. No wonder these cities were central to the state's positioning of faith as a cultural and economic engine. But now, Uttar Pradesh is trawling deeper into its spiritual geography: quieter places on its native map of the soul that the pan-India throngs are less familiar with, places that tap into a 'little culture' distinct from the Hindu mainstream.

Across that scattered landscape, stretching from Gorakhpur in eastern UP to Mahoba in Bundelkhand, the state is seeking to spruce up its old Nathpanthi spiritual circuit into a modern pilgrim tourism network. The circuit will connect temples, caves, monasteries, meditation centres and religious sites linked to the